



La Commune

Director: Peter Watkins

Production Companies: 13 Production, La Sept, ARTE, Musée d'Orsay

Producer: Paul Saadoun

Unit Production Managers: Dominic Lavail, Christel Martinet

Production Manager: Marie-Josée Godin

Casting: Patrick Watkins, Virginie Guibbaud

Director of Photography: Odd Geir Saether

Chief Lighting Technician: Clarisse Gatti

Editors: Peter Watkins, Agathe Bluysen, Patrick Watkins

Art Director: Patrice Le Turcq

Sound: Jean-François Priseter

France 2000

345 mins + intervals

Digital

There will be a 60min interval after Part One and then a shorter 15min comfort break halfway through Part Two

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System Critical: The Radical Films of Peter Watkins

La Commune

Peter Watkins on 'La Commune'

My purpose in making *La Commune* was not to 'document' or 'represent' (both dangerous words!) the history of the Commune in the form of a typical TV documentary, nor to tell a 'story', as in a Hollywood narrative saga, but rather to work with the very essence of the film form, to find out if it was possible to transcend the limiting experiences of traditional television and the commercial cinema. I wanted to explore if it was possible to move outside the traditional limitations of the rectangular frame into a more complex and democratic process with the audience – meaning with the community in general. In attempting this, I hoped that the FORM and PROCESS of our film would also help to develop a debate on the links between the forces which crushed the Commune, and those which today still prevent social collectivism from flourishing on almost any spot on this planet.

Production notes

We are now moving through a very bleak period in human history – where the conjunction of postmodernist cynicism (eliminating humanistic and critical thinking in the education system), sheer greed engendered by the consumer society sweeping many people under its wing, human, economic and environmental catastrophe in the form of globalisation, massively increased suffering and exploitation of the people of the so-called Third World, as well as the mind-numbing conformity and standardisation caused by the systematic audio-visualisation of the planet have synergistically created a world where ethics, morality, human collectivity, and commitment (except to opportunism) are considered 'old fashioned'. Where excess and economic exploitation have become the norm – to be taught even to children. In such a world as this, what happened in Paris in the spring of 1871 represented (and still represents) the idea of commitment to a struggle for a better world, and of the need for some form of collective social Utopia – which WE now need as desperately as dying people need plasma. The notion of a film showing this commitment was thus born.

In February 1998 I met with Paul Saadoun of 13 Production, a documentary film company based in Marseilles, and we agreed to produce a film on the Paris Commune. During 16 months of intensive research and pre-production, with the exception of La Sept ARTE in France, all of the major global TV associations which were approached, refused to participate in funding for the film. 'I do not like Peter Watkins' films,' said the Commissioning Editor for the BBC in London. Early in 1999, one of the major art centres in Paris – the Musée d'Orsay – learned of our film, decided to organise an exhibition on the Paris Commune (consisting of contemporary photographs, and the works of Corbet, a member of the Commune), and allocated 300,000 francs to our film budget. It is interesting in this context to note that cultural institutions, museums, and art galleries are beginning to fill the vacuum left by the increasingly conservative MAVM, which has all but ceased to produce serious works for the mass market!

The filming of *La Commune* took place in July 1999, in an abandoned factory in Montreuil, on the eastern edge of Paris. The factory stands on the site of the former film studios of French film pioneer Georges Méliès (1861-1938). Méliès,

System Critical: The Radical Films of Peter Watkins

The War Game

Sun 2 Aug 17:45 (+ Samira Ahmed remembers Peter Watkins in an extended conversation with Kevin Brownlow and Kodwo Eshun); Mon 17 Aug 18:20 (+ intro by season co-curator William Fowler)

Peter Watkins: Resistance Isn't Futile

Tue 4 Aug 18:15

Punishment Park

Wed 5 Aug 20:50; Fri 14 Aug 18:15

Peter Watkins and the Playcraft Film Unit

Thu 6 Aug 18:20; Mon 17 Aug 21:10

Privilege

Sat 8 Aug 15:30; Thu 13 Aug 20:45

Culloden + The Making of Culloden

Sun 9 Aug 12:40; Wed 12 Aug 20:40

The Gladiators

aka The Peace Game or Gladiatoren

Sun 9 Aug 15:10; Wed 19 Aug 20:40

Dream of a World

Mon 10 Aug 18:00

Radical Cinema: Past, Present and Future

Histories + Onyeka Igwe in conversation with William Fowler

Thu 13 Aug 18:15

The 70s People 70'ernes folk

Sat 15 Aug 12:20; Mon 24 Aug 20:30

Evening Land Aftenlandet

Sat 15 Aug 20:40; Fri 28 Aug 18:15

Edvard Munch

Sun 16 Aug 14:45; Mon 31 Aug 14:30

The Trap Fällan

Fri 21 Aug 18:20; Wed 26 Aug 20:40

The Journey

Sat 22 Aug (Parts 1-8); Sun 23 Aug (Parts 9-12);

Sat 29 Aug (Parts 13-19)

The Freethinker Fritänkaren

Sun 23 Aug 14:40

The Universal Clock:

The Resistance of Peter Watkins

Tue 25 Aug 18:30

The Media Project

Thu 27 Aug 18:00

La Commune

Sun 30 Aug 12:00

With thanks to

Patrick and Gerard Watkins, Gareth Evans, Leo Goldsmith, Nina Gosling, Sarah Gosling, Oliver Groom, Stephen Mercer and Kris Woods

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who died in poverty, discovered and exploited many of the basic camera tricks used in the cinema: stop motion, slow motion, dissolve, fade-out, superimposition, and double exposure. From 1899 to 1912 he produced more than 400 films, the best of which combine illusion, comic burlesque, and pantomime – treating themes of fantasy in a playful and absurd fashion. Méliès' films include *Cleopatra* and *Christ Walking on the Waters* (1899), *A Trip to the Moon* (1902), and *Voyage across the Impossible* (1904). Given the nature of our own film, it is interesting to note that Georges Méliès also filmed studio reconstructions of news events – an early type of newsreel. The factory which was built on the site of the Méliès studios recently became a performance venue for the theatre group 'La Parole errante', which, under the administration of Jean-Jacques Hocquard, is based around the work of dramatist, poet and director Armand Gatti.

Working with Agathe Bluysen, one of our main researchers, and our casting crew – principally my elder son Patrick, and Virginie Guibbaud – I enlisted over 220 people from Paris and the provinces to take part in the film; approximately 60% of them had no prior acting experience. Among the cast were a number of people from Picardy and other regions of France, with specific dialects and accents (since many migrants from the provinces took an active role in the Commune). Through the conservative press in Versailles, and newspapers like *Le Figaro*, we also recruited people from the Paris area to join the project specifically because of their conservative politics (to act in roles opposed to the Commune).

The set in the disused factory was designed and constructed by Patrice Le Turcq as a series of interconnecting rooms and spaces, designed to represent the working-class 11th district of Paris, a centre of revolutionary activity during the Commune. The set was carefully designed to 'hover' between reality and theatricality, with careful and loving detail applied for example to the texture of the walls, but with the edges of the set always visible, and with the 'exteriors' – the Rue Popincourt and the central Place Voltaire – clearly seen for what they are – artificial elements within an interior space.

Cinematographer Odd Geir Saether filmed *Edvard Munch* in 1973. To implement my plan in *La Commune* for long, highly mobile uninterrupted takes, Saether and chief lighting technician Clarisse Gatti covered the ceiling of the factory with regularly spaced special neon lights, to give an even luminescence to the whole area, and to prevent the use of traditional lights on the floor obstructing the path of the hand-held camera. Jean-François Priester developed an equally ingenious method for the highly mobile and flexible recording of the sound, using two boom operators with radio-microphones and portable mixing system, which moved around the labyrinthine set.

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